

THE LAST FREQUENCY

T O M E O N E



A MYSTERY THRILLER

AIRID

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*"The truth is a frequency.
Some people spend their whole lives
on the wrong station."*

AIRID

Author & Editor

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Written and edited by Airid

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CHAPTER ONE

Static

The radio tower had been silent for six days when Zara Okafor decided to climb it.

Most people in Millhaven drove past the old tower on Route 9 without a second glance. It was just another relic of the town's brief moment of relevance -- back when Millhaven Community Radio broadcast everything from school cancellations to late-night jazz, back before the internet killed the airwaves and the airwaves took half the town's sense of itself along for the ride. But Zara had grown up listening to that tower. Her father used to tune the kitchen radio to 91.7 FM every Sunday morning, balancing it on the windowsill above the sink so the signal would come in clear. The static crackle before the signal locked in was, to her, the sound of home. Not the sound of happiness, necessarily -- her childhood had been complicated in ways she was still untangling at twenty-two -- but the sound of place. Of belonging to a specific stretch of road in a specific broken-down town that was, for better or worse, hers.

Now it was just crackle. No signal. She had noticed it five days ago when she started her Sunday morning routine alone, the kitchen radio finding nothing on 91.7 but white noise. Technical trouble, she had assumed. But five days had become six, and something about the silence had begun to bother her in a way she could not name and did not want to ignore.

She parked her secondhand Civic on the gravel shoulder of Route 9 and stepped out into the thick August heat. The tower rose about two hundred feet from a flat scrub lot -- a rusted lattice of steel painted once, long ago, in red and white, the colors faded now to uniform rust-orange. Against a sky that had settled into a noncommittal haze, it looked like a monument to something nobody had bothered to specify. At its peak, the red aviation warning light blinked on and off, steady as a pulse. The power was on, at least.

A chain-link fence ringed the base. A padlocked gate bore a sign in faded stencil: AUTHORIZED PERSONNEL ONLY -- MILLHAVEN BROADCASTING CO. Below it, a newer plastic sign: PROPERTY UNDER SURVEILLANCE.

Zara had never been authorized for anything in her twenty-two years. Her high school guidance counselor had called her relentless curiosity a liability. Her father, on good days, called it her sharpest tool.

She found the gap in the fence where two panels had been bent back -- she had found it first at sixteen, when this place was a dare. Back then she and her best friend Deon would sneak in and sit on the equipment shed steps and talk about getting out of Millhaven. Deon was in Atlanta now, working in software, sending birthday cards that always arrived two days late. Zara had not gotten out. She had meant to. Her father's stroke had changed the timing, and then the timing had become irrelevant.

She squeezed through the gap and approached the equipment shed -- a low cinder-block building with a steel door, sitting in the tower's long shadow. She had expected the usual: the old rusted Master Lock, maybe a county notice. Instead she found a new padlock. Heavy, brass, commercial-grade. It hung on the old hasp, but the hasp itself was wrong. She crouched and examined it in the flattening afternoon light.

Fresh scratch marks around the screws. The marks of a door forced quickly and then refastened from the outside.

Someone had been inside very recently and had replaced the lock on their way out.

She stood and photographed everything -- the lock, the scratches, the signs -- from three angles. Then she stepped back and looked at the shed, the tower, the empty lot. A semi rolled past on Route 9 without slowing. A crow landed on the fence thirty yards away and watched her with the profound disinterest of a creature that has seen everything.

Her phone buzzed. UNKNOWN NUMBER. A text, arriving a second later: Stop looking, Zara. This is not your business.

She read it twice. She looked around the empty lot. Nobody. She photographed the text. Then she walked back to her car, sat in the driver's seat with the engine off, and spent three deliberate minutes being afraid. She had learned that it was important to let yourself be afraid when fear was the right response, rather than performing courage over the top of it and making bad decisions.

Three minutes. Then she drove two blocks to the Millhaven Public Library. If someone wanted her to stop looking, whatever she was looking at was real. And if it was real, she needed to understand it before it understood her.

CHAPTER TWO

The Archive

The Millhaven Public Library smelled like new carpet in the front and old carpet in the back -- a consequence of a 2019 renovation grant that had stretched exactly far enough to run out at the reference desk. Behind that desk, as she had been for as long as Zara could remember, sat Ms. Vera Petrov: sixty-three, sharp-eyed behind tortoiseshell glasses, possessed of opinions on nearly everything, and conducting a surveillance of Zara that had begun in the seventh grade and showed no signs of concluding.

Newspaper archives, Zara said at the desk. Last three weeks. Anything about the radio tower or Millhaven Broadcasting.

Ms. Petrov applied what Zara privately called the Appraisal -- a careful, unhurried evaluation. You are not a journalist, she said.

No, ma'am.

Then why are you researching the radio tower?

Because it went silent six days ago and I want to know why. It matters to people in this town.

The Appraisal continued another moment. Then: You have that look again. The look that has, over the years, preceded you discovering that the booster club treasurer was embezzling, that the church parking lot was being used for something inappropriate, and that the new grocery manager was pricing items differently for different customers. I still do not fully understand how you figured that last one out.

He had two price sticker rolls in his apron and I noticed the pattern.

Regardless. Ms. Petrov stood. Follow me.

The microfiche room was in the back, past the old carpet smell, in a small space that also housed a broken printer and boxes of donated books nobody had processed yet. The Millhaven Courier archives went back to 1962 on microfiche

and to 2004 as scanned PDFs.

The shutdown story ran four paragraphs on page eight of Tuesday's edition. The official account was thin: Millhaven Broadcasting's license had lapsed following the death of its owner, Gerald P. Marsh, age seventy-four, who had operated the station since 1987. His estate was being administered by a Wilmington law firm. No timeline for return. No details on future ownership. The item felt like the absence of information dressed up as information.

She searched Marsh's name across two decades of archives. He appeared rarely -- a source quoted here, a donor acknowledged there. A private man who had run a public-facing business without ever becoming a public figure. His death notice confirmed it: Gerald Peter Marsh, 74. No survivors listed. Services private.

She moved to property records on the county website. The tower site at 1144 Route 9 had been owned by Millhaven Broadcasting Co. since 1985. Property taxes for the current year had been paid in full three weeks ago, by wire transfer, from an LLC called Clearwave Holdings.

She searched Clearwave Holdings. Delaware registration, filed fourteen months ago. No public website. Registered agent: a Wilmington firm specializing in discreet asset management and corporate structuring for clients requiring confidentiality.

Someone had acquired the tower recently and quietly, and had no interest in being found.

Her phone buzzed. It was Marcus.

You need to come home. His voice was controlled in the way that meant something was not. There is something here you need to see.

What kind of something?

The pause lasted too long to mean nothing. The kind that makes more sense in person. Just come home, Z. Please.

She saved her notes, thanked Ms. Petrov, and drove to Clement Street.

CHAPTER THREE

The Box

The house on Clement Street was a craftsman bungalow their father had bought in 1995 for forty thousand dollars -- a real amount of money, in this part of Ohio, at the time. He had re-shingled the roof twice, rebuilt the front porch steps, and planted the maple tree that now filled the front yard so completely that the house was invisible from the street in summer. Zara had always loved this. The feeling that the house was protected. Hidden. Specifically theirs.

Marcus met her at the door carrying the lockbox under his arm like it had committed an offense he had not yet decided how to address. Dad wants to talk to you first, he said quietly. Before you see this.

Their father, Joseph Okafor, sat in his wheelchair by the back window with a paperback mystery open on his lap -- he was working through Agatha Christie in publication order since the stroke -- but he was not reading. He was looking at the maple tree.

He looked up when Zara came in and smiled the smile she had never been able to adequately describe to anyone who had not seen it for themselves.

My investigator, he said.

I am not an investigator, Dad.

You have always been investigating something. Even at four years old. Why is the sugar in the cabinet. Who left this shoe in the bathroom. How do the birds know which way is south. The smile faded toward something more careful. Marcus says you were at the tower today.

Someone sent me a text telling me to stop looking. Which means there is something worth looking at.

He nodded slowly. Before Marcus shows you what he found, I need to tell you something. Something I should have told you years ago and did not, because I was ashamed and because I believed the chapter was finished.

He told her about Aldric Voss. Not in one breath -- it came the way difficult truths often do, in pieces, with pauses between them that she did not fill.

When he was twenty-eight, newly arrived from Lagos, broke and afraid of staying broke, a man named Voss had offered him work. Importing, they called it. He had known within three months that some of the imports were illegal, and he had chosen -- this was the word he returned to, chosen -- not to look at it directly. He had done this for two years. Then he stopped. He told Voss he was done. Voss was not pleased. But Joseph Okafor was small and Voss was careful, and small problems were beneath his direct attention.

I went to work for Gerald at the station, and Gerald never asked about my history, and years went by. Two weeks ago a man came to the door. Said he was from the gas company. Marcus was out. I let him in. He went to the basement. His voice held the flat cadence of a fact being stated without complaint. My chair does not fit the stairs. I could not follow him.

He left something.

Or he found something already there. Marcus discovered it that afternoon.

Marcus appeared in the doorway and set the metal lockbox on the table. Gunmetal gray. A latch lock that had been pried open and bent back into a semblance of closure. It was behind the water heater, Marcus said. In a gap in the wall patched with new concrete -- you could tell from the color.

So it was not left by the visitor, Zara said. It was already there. And he came to point you toward it.

Or to confirm it was still there, her father said. Gerald always planned several steps ahead.

She looked at the box, at her father, at Marcus. Can I? she said. And lifted the bent latch.

CHAPTER FOUR

What Was Inside

Inside the lockbox: a 2.5-inch external hard drive sealed in a zip-lock bag, a burner smartphone still in retail packaging, and a single sheet of cream-colored stationery folded in thirds -- the kind of paper that communicated deliberateness just by existing.

She unfolded the note. The handwriting was careful and slightly formal, the script of someone who had learned penmanship when it was still taught as a discipline worth mastering.

The note read: OKAFOR -- When the time comes, you will know what to do with the frequency. Play it. Let it reach who it needs to reach. You were never the guilty one. I am sorry it took me so long to say that. Destroy this note after reading. M.

She read it three times.

M, she said. Gerald Marsh.

My first thought, her father said. But Gerald is dead.

He could have written this before he died. Arranged for someone to place it here before he died. She turned the note over. Nothing on the back. Someone else knew about this, Dad. The visitor came to point you toward it -- or to confirm it had not been found and removed.

She picked up the hard drive, careful through the bag. The brand markings on the casing had been sanded off, leaving a dull patch. She turned it over and found, scratched into the underside in thin careful letters: 91.7.

She held it up so her father could see. Something behind his expression shifted.

The station frequency, he said.

Play the frequency -- that is what the note says. Not look at it or read it. Play it. Like audio content.

A recording, Marcus said slowly. Something meant to be broadcast.

Maybe. Whatever is on this drive connects to the station somehow. She set it down. Has anyone turned on the phone?

No.

Good. She pulled out her own phone and typed a reply to the unknown number: WHO ARE YOU. She sent it and waited.

Twenty seconds. Thirty. The reply came: FREQUENCY. Then, eight seconds later: TOWER. MIDNIGHT. COME ALONE.

She showed Marcus. He read it with the expression of a man watching someone step onto a bridge of uncertain integrity.

Absolutely not, he said.

I am not going to a dark industrial site alone to meet a stranger. I am going to Priya's first. Rohan can examine the drive. Then we figure out together what tonight means and whether it is something I can approach with any degree of safety.

Safety, Marcus repeated, testing the word.

More safety, she amended. She touched her father's arm. Is there anything else I should know before I start pulling this thread?

He was quiet. The clock on the windowsill ticked. Outside, the maple moved in a light wind. Voss is not a man who forgives proximity to his secrets, he said finally. Be very careful who you trust.

I always am.

No, he said, not unkindly. You are careful about facts. You are sometimes too trusting of people. Balance the two.

She kissed his forehead and went to find out what was on the drive.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Recording

Priya Sharma's apartment was a third-floor walkup above a closed nail salon on Merchant Street, permanently scented by the Thai restaurant next door, which nobody in the apartment had ever complained about. Priya was twenty-three, finishing a communications degree remotely, and had been Zara's closest friend since adjacent ninth-grade lockers revealed identical opinions about their English teacher.

Her boyfriend Rohan occupied most of the second bedroom with equipment that Zara had long since stopped trying to fully inventory: multiple monitors, a rack of hard drives, signal-scanning hardware, a soldering station, and technical manuals he had read cover to cover and still periodically consulted. He worked remotely for a Columbus cybersecurity firm and had the focused, slightly elsewhere quality of someone whose mind was always running a background process.

He accepted the hard drive with the careful attention of a doctor receiving a patient and connected it to an air-gapped laptop -- no network access, completely isolated. Clean, he said ten minutes later. No payload, no self-destruct mechanism. Whoever built this was preserving information, not attacking. Two partitions. First is encrypted -- AES-256, military-grade, not breaking that tonight. Second partition is completely open. One file. A WAV audio file. Raw, uncompressed. Forty-seven minutes and eighteen seconds.

Play it, Zara said.

The first thirty seconds were static -- dense, layered, the noise of something old recorded in analog and then carefully digitized. Then, beneath the static, a voice. Male, low, deliberate. Speaking in a language Zara felt in her chest before her brain caught up with it.

Igbo. Her father's language, which he had taught her in fragments over years of stubborn repetition -- the way parents keep a thread alive when they are afraid it might break. Her Igbo was imperfect. She understood more than she spoke. But she understood enough.

The voice was reciting. Names. Dates. Account numbers. A location in Michigan. Something about shipments, about arrangements, about a man in a city who needed protection and the precise cost of that protection. Reciting the way you would dictate records for posterity -- careful, complete, intended to survive.

Then a second voice. Younger. Tentative at first, then gathering itself into something more deliberate. Answering questions. Confirming details. Adding context the first voice had not supplied.

She recognized the second voice before she had time to prepare for recognizing it. It lived in the part of her memory where formative things lived -- the part that does not wait for permission to surface.

Her father. Twenty years younger. Telling the truth to someone who was recording every word of it.

Stop, she said. Rohan stopped the playback. The waveform froze on the screen. The apartment was very quiet.

Do you know what that is? Priya asked softly.

Testimony, Zara said. My father gave someone a full account of Aldric Voss's operations. Someone recorded it and kept it for twenty years. She looked at the frozen waveform. The note said to play the frequency. If this goes out on 91.7 -- even for an hour -- anyone recording the signal gets a copy automatically. Journalists, law enforcement, anyone with a scanner. It becomes public record the moment it airs.

That is the plan, Rohan said quietly.

That is the plan. But I need to understand everything on this drive before I do anything with it. All forty-seven minutes. And I need a full translation.

I can find a transcription service, Rohan said.

No third parties. She had heard her father say Be careful who you trust. I will do it myself.

Then start now, Priya said, and handed her a pen and a fresh notebook.

It took three and a half hours. When she finished she had four pages of careful notes and a cold specific feeling behind her sternum. The recording was not her father confessing to crimes. It was her father -- under evident pressure but speaking with increasing steadiness -- giving testimony about someone else's crimes. Naming amounts, transactions, contacts, methods. And the voice guiding him through the account, she now understood, belonged to Gerald Marsh. Patient. Careful. Building a record intended to outlast him.

Throughout the recording, surfacing again and again like a name carved into a foundation stone: Aldric Voss.

CHAPTER SIX

The Name Nobody Says

She searched Aldric Voss through every database she could access from Priya's kitchen table: public records, archived news, property filings, court documents.

He surfaced in Millhaven records only in fragments. A 1994 newspaper piece about a civic grant listed him among a dozen donors. A 1997 business license filing for Voss Holdings. A 1999 bankruptcy filing subsequently withdrawn. A 2003 building permit under a related entity. After 2005: nothing. As if he had simply stopped existing.

People do not stop existing, Rohan said, reading over her shoulder. They change their name, restructure their companies, or they die very quietly.

Or someone helps them disappear, Priya said from the doorway. Which is a different thing.

Clearwave Holdings -- the LLC that bought the tower, Zara said. If Voss controls it, then he has just moved to own the one transmitter Gerald Marsh implied contained his records. He is trying to control the signal before anyone can use it.

Which means whoever left the drive in your basement is working against Voss, Rohan said. And they chose you because you have no connection to any of it. You are deniable.

Or expendable.

Let us try to make those two things different, Priya said firmly.

Zara went home and sat with her father and said only the name: Aldric Voss.

The effect was immediate and total. Her father's hands went still in a way that was different from ordinary stillness. The paperback did not move. Outside, a car passed on Clement Street and the headlights swept across the ceiling and were gone.

Where did you hear that name, he said. Not a question. The recognition of something long-awaited.

On the recording. Dad -- Gerald recorded your testimony and kept it for twenty years. Someone has now placed it in our basement and told me to broadcast it on 91.7. I need to know: who would Gerald have trusted with this? Who has been coordinating all of this since he died?

Her father thought for a long time. The clock on the windowsill ticked. A neighbor's dog barked twice and stopped.

Gerald had a sister, he said finally. Constance. I met her once, years ago. She was formidable. The kind of person who finishes things that other people only start.

Zara looked at her phone. TOWER. MIDNIGHT. COME ALONE.

I am going, she said.

Her father reached out and gripped her hand with the strength the stroke had not taken. Voss has operated for forty years in places that did not want to see him and has become very good at remaining unseen. Whatever you do tonight -- do not go alone. I know you will go. Just do not go alone.

She squeezed his hand back. I will not.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Midnight

She did not go alone.

She had told the number she would come alone, and in the narrow sense that mattered she would -- she would enter the gate alone, without Marcus standing beside her. But alone is a relative concept.

Marcus followed in his pickup truck, lights off, parked a quarter mile down Route 9 with instructions to call 911 if she did not text him every fifteen minutes and to use his own judgment if he heard anything that sounded like a problem. Priya monitored a police scanner app from her apartment. Rohan had traced the unknown number's cell signal to within half a mile of the tower site.

Zara wore dark clothes and sensible shoes. She brought her phone, a small flashlight, and the pepper spray from the bottom of her bag. She brought herself, her notebook, and the ability to run if necessary.

Route 9 at midnight was quiet in the way of secondary roads -- not dead, but resting. The occasional truck. The occasional sweep of headlights and then darkness again. The stars had resolved the day's haze into genuine clarity, lying across the sky with the indifferent abundance of stars in places where the light pollution has not quite won.

The gravel lot was empty. The aviation light blinked: on, off, on, off.

The gate stood open. She photographed it, then pushed through. Light leaked from the edges of the equipment shed door -- the thin yellow seam of a lantern, not overhead fluorescents. She nudged the door open.

Inside: the lantern on a workbench. Old equipment on every surface -- transmitters, cable coils, logbooks, the accumulated hardware of nearly forty years of broadcasting. And in the back, distinctly newer than everything surrounding it: a laptop connected to a signal interface and a modified transmitter board.

And a woman in a folding chair near the lantern, watching Zara with the composed attention of someone who has been waiting a long time and has made peace with waiting.

She was perhaps sixty. White hair, cut short. A canvas work jacket. A weathered face organized around a quality Zara recognized after a moment as a lifetime of paying attention to things that mattered.

You came, the woman said. Not relief. Verification of a hypothesis.

Constance Marsh, Zara said.

A slight pause. Your father told you about me.

He said Gerald had a sister. He said you were the kind of person who finishes things.

Something moved behind Constance Marsh's careful eyes -- grief and pride occupying the same space, indistinguishable at this distance. Gerald said the same. It was his best compliment. She gestured to the second folding chair. Sit. We have time, but not unlimited time. When the transmitter goes live, a monitoring sensor on this property will trip. I estimate ninety minutes before anyone arrives. I need you to understand everything before that clock starts.

Zara sat.

Constance told her about Gerald -- not the version in the newspaper, but the private version. A man who had spent thirty years building a case against the person who had corrupted him. Who had constructed a meticulous archive of everything he had witnessed and done and enabled. Who had told no one and trusted no one except, at the very end, his sister.

The drive in your father's basement was Gerald's design, Constance said. A failsafe. He believed your father deserved the chance to have his testimony be the thing that ended Voss rather than the thing that ended him.

Why my family? Why not go directly to law enforcement or a journalist?

Gerald tried law enforcement once, in 2004. One of the officials he had identified in his records -- a county prosecutor -- received a quiet call two days later and the inquiry stopped. He never tried again. As for journalists -- Gerald was a private man who had spent thirty years as a criminal co-conspirator. Any

accusation he made would be immediately challenged on those grounds. It needed to come from the signal itself. From the station's own frequency. Undeniable. Public. Recorded simultaneously by everyone who was listening.

And I am credible because I have no connection to any of it.

You are credible because you are Joseph Okafor's daughter, and you found this yourself, and nobody paid you to. Constance held her gaze steadily. Are you willing?

Zara looked at the transmitter setup. At this woman with her dead brother's life's work arranged around her like a vigil. She thought about her father's shaking hands. About the weight he had been carrying since he was twenty-eight years old.

Show me how to operate the transmitter, she said.

CHAPTER EIGHT

On the Air

Constance was an efficient teacher. The modified transmitter required three steps to bring live: power sequence, signal lock, queue initiation. She walked Zara through each step twice, had her repeat the sequence from memory, then watched while Zara ran through it a final time with her hands.

Zara texted Marcus: I am okay. Stand by. Do not call police. Text me back. The reply came in four seconds: confirmed. standing by. please do not die.

She texted Priya: Call your contact at the Register. Tell her to tune to 91.7 right now and set it recording. Tell her it is important. Do not explain yet.

Priya replied: already calling. what is happening zara.

Ready? Constance asked.

The encrypted partition opened with a passphrase Constance had memorized in the hospital during Gerald's last weeks. The file directory that loaded was enormous: forty-seven audio tracks organized by date, with a single header track at the front that Zara had not yet heard.

She pressed play on the header.

Gerald Marsh's voice filled the equipment shed. It was older than the voice on the main recording -- slower, more deliberate, with the careful weight of a man making his final statement and wanting every word to be correct. He explained what the material represented. He named Aldric Voss. He stated explicitly that the testimony of Joseph Okafor had been given voluntarily and represented the account of a cooperating witness, not a criminal participant. He said he was sorry it had taken this long, and that he hoped it was not too late.

Constance looked at her hands while her brother's voice spoke. She did not move.

When the header track finished, Zara queued all forty-seven files in sequence and confirmed the broadcast settings. Once this runs, it runs itself? she

asked.

All the way through to the end. Ninety-one minutes of material. We should be well away before anyone arrives. Constance stood and began packing efficiently -- the tablet, the thermos, the few things she had brought. I have a car around the back. There is a track behind the property that does not appear on maps.

Zara looked at the transmitter. At the queue. At the waveform of her father's young voice waiting at the front of track two.

She pressed broadcast.

The signal meter's needle swung to the right and held. The transmitter hummed with the particular tone of electronics finding their purpose. Thirty miles in every direction, on car radios and kitchen radios and scanner setups and emergency monitors, 91.7 FM came back from the dead.

She stood still for a moment, feeling the low hum through the soles of her shoes. Somewhere out in the August night, in cars and kitchens and newsrooms, the signal was arriving.

Let us go, Constance said.

They left the shed door open. The transmitter broadcast behind them. Zara looked back once at the tower -- the aviation light blinking steadily, on and off, on and off -- and then followed Constance into the field. The signal carried.

CHAPTER NINE

What the Signal Reached

Sasha Chen had been a journalist for four years and had been told by her editor, her parents, and two professors that she had the instincts for a much bigger market than Millhaven. She had interpreted this as a compliment and a directive she was free to ignore. She was still in the newsroom at midnight because she was always still in the newsroom.

When the text arrived from Priya -- tune 91.7 now, record everything, it is important -- Sasha's desk radio was already on. She tuned it in time to catch Gerald Marsh's introduction from the beginning.

She recognized, with the alertness of someone who has been waiting for a story without knowing what story they were waiting for, that what she was hearing was significant. She started recording within ninety seconds. She called her editor, who was asleep, and left a message she was confident would produce action. She called the paper's attorney to confirm that receiving and reporting on a public broadcast created no liability. Then she called two journalists she trusted at regional outlets and told them to tune in immediately.

By the time the signal died at 1:35 AM, the ninety-one minutes of material had been captured in full by Sasha, two regional reporters, an investigative journalist at a Columbus daily who happened to be awake and monitoring scanner traffic, and -- this would matter considerably in the weeks that followed -- an analyst with the FBI's Columbus field office who had the feed running in the background and had, in a moment of professional attention, turned up the volume when an unfamiliar name surfaced in the recording.

Aldric Voss.

The analyst made three phone calls before 3 AM.

By 4 AM, the Millhaven Courier website had posted Sasha's first story. By 7 AM it had been picked up by six regional outlets and two national ones. By 9

AM, the FBI's field office had issued a brief statement confirming the bureau was reviewing materials obtained from the broadcast.

Zara read the first headline from the passenger seat of Constance's car in a Denny's parking lot in the next county. The coffee from the thermos had run out an hour ago. The diner had just opened for the early shift and the smell of coffee drifted through a cracked window.

Is it going to be enough? she asked.

Enough to start, Constance said. Enough to finish takes longer. There will be lawyers, challenges to provenance and admissibility, people paid to raise doubts. Voss has resources and he will use them. She set her phone down. But the recordings exist and are now in the possession of federal authorities and multiple news organizations. You cannot un-ring a bell.

Marcus had texted eleven times. Zara called him.

I am fine, she said. Everyone is fine. Tell Dad to turn on the news.

A long pause. Then: Zara. Is this your fault?

Partly.

How big of a partly?

The interesting kind.

Something that might have been a suppressed laugh. Come home.

CHAPTER TEN

Morning on Clement Street

She arrived on Clement Street at eight thirty. The maple threw cool shadows across the porch. The house looked exactly as it always had, which struck her, under the circumstances, as remarkable.

Her father was awake. He had been awake for hours -- the television showed the news, and his face showed the exhausted focus of someone who has been processing difficult information and has not yet arrived anywhere comfortable.

She sat across from him and told him everything. She left nothing out. When she finished, he was quiet for a long time.

Gerald's voice, he said finally. I have not heard it in eight months.

His introduction is on the recording. If the press releases it -- and they will -- you will be able to hear it.

I do not know if I want to. He looked at his hands. He kept all of this for thirty years and said nothing to me. He could have told me.

He protected you by not telling you. If you had known the record existed, you would have been a liability to him and a target for Voss. She leaned forward. Dad -- the way he framed your testimony, he built it specifically to exonerate you. Your voice is not a confession. It is a witness statement. That was the architecture of the whole thing.

He protected himself too.

Yes. Both things are true. People who help us are not always purely motivated. That does not make the help less real.

He looked at her for a long moment. Then he said, You sound like your mother. It was the highest compliment he knew how to give.

Marcus cooked breakfast -- eggs, toast, fruit, coffee -- with the focused energy of a man who needed to be useful and had settled on this as the available form. The phone rang four times during breakfast. Twice it was journalists. Once

an unrecognized number she let go to voicemail. Once an attorney in Columbus retained by the Courier, who wanted to speak with whoever had been at the tower.

That would be me, she said.

Can we meet today?

Tomorrow at ten.

She agreed and hung up and looked at Marcus, who was watching her with the expression of someone who has not yet decided whether to be furious or proud and is managing the uncertainty through the discipline of cooking.

What? she said.

Nothing, he said. Eat your eggs.

She ate her eggs. Outside the maple moved in a morning breeze and the light shifted through it the way it had shifted for thirty years -- patient, indifferent, and exactly right.

EPILOGUE

The Signal Carries

Six months later, the federal indictment named fourteen individuals, six shell companies, and a network of financial arrangements that had operated across four states for the better part of twenty years. The document ran to 340 pages. The lead prosecutor described it, in a press briefing, as one of the most meticulously documented fraud cases the office had encountered -- owing, she noted, to the unusual method by which the core evidence had entered the public record.

Aldric Voss was arrested at Douglas International Airport in Charlotte at 6:14 in the morning on a Tuesday, attempting to board a flight to a country with no extradition agreement with the United States. He was sixty-seven years old. In the photographs taken at the arrest, he looked like a man who had known for a very long time that a particular morning would eventually arrive and had never quite managed to believe it.

He entered a not guilty plea, retained six attorneys, and filed seventeen motions in the first three months. Two challenged the admissibility of the broadcast evidence on grounds of provenance. Both were denied. Trial was scheduled for the following year.

Joseph Okafor gave voluntary testimony to federal investigators over two days in October. He was thorough and honest and declined on principle to have legal counsel present, which his daughter argued with him about strenuously and lost. He was not charged. The prosecutor who took his statement told him afterward, in a moment of informality she would not have documented, that in thirty years of practice she had rarely encountered a witness who had done more to make her job straightforward.

He said he was glad to finally be useful.

Constance Marsh gave one interview -- to the Millhaven Register -- in which she described as much of Gerald's plan as she believed it useful to describe, and declined to speculate on the rest. She received letters afterward from former listeners, from strangers, from a former FCC official who said he wished he had known Gerald Marsh. She answered each letter by hand. It took her three months.

Marcus Okafor returned to his job and his life and texted his sister links to case-related news articles approximately four times a week, always captioned with some variation of please never do this again. She always replied with some variation of no promises. This became, over time, a form of love.

Sasha filed eleven more stories on the Voss case over six months. She was offered a position at a regional daily and declined it. The Millhaven Register gave her a raise, which she accepted.

Zara left the Sunrise Diner in December -- not because of anything dramatic, but because a small investigative nonprofit in Columbus needed someone who was, in the words of the hiring manager, constitutionally incapable of leaving a thread alone. She took the position. She drove back to Millhaven every second weekend.

Millhaven Community Radio, after a community fundraising campaign that exceeded its goal in eleven days, received a new broadcast license in March. The ribbon-cutting was attended by most of the town.

The first thing they played when the transmitter went live was an hour of late-night jazz.

Zara sat in her father's kitchen with the radio on the windowsill -- the same radio that had always lived there, the antenna tilted at the same angle her father had found worked best -- and listened to the music arrive from thirty miles away, carried on a frequency that had told the truth and was now telling something gentler.

The crackle before the signal locked in sounded exactly as it always had. Imperfect. A little rough. Reaching out across the dark for whoever might be listening.

She thought it sounded exactly right.

-- End of Tome One --

THE LAST FREQUENCY

TOME ONE

Continue the story in Tome Two -- coming soon.

AIRID